Pride and Prejudice

An Authoritative Text with Archival Notes

By Jane Austen

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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

Elizabeth Bennet and Fitzwilliam Darcy navigate first impressions, family obligations, and social rank in Regency Hertfordshire.

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CHAPTER I

Arrival at Netherfield Park

Complete Unabridged Text (1813 Edition)

It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a single man in possession of a good fortune, must be in want of a wife.

However little known the feelings or views of such a man may be on his first entering a neighbourhood, this truth is so well fixed in the minds of the surrounding families, that he is considered the rightful property of some one or other of their daughters.

"My dear Mr. Bennet," said his lady to him one day, "have you heard that Netherfield Park is let at last?"

Mr. Bennet replied that he had not.

"But it is," returned she; "for Mrs. Long has just been here, and she told me all about it."

Mr. Bennet made no answer.

"Do you not want to know who has taken it?" cried his wife impatiently.

"You want to tell me, and I have no objection to hearing it."

This was invitation enough.

"Why, my dear, you must know, Mrs. Long says that Netherfield is taken by a young man of large fortune from the north of England; that he came down on Monday in a chaise and four to see the place, and was so much delighted with it, that he agreed with Mr. Morris immediately; that he is to take possession before Michaelmas, and some of his servants are to be in the house by the end of next week."

"What is his name?"

"Bingley."

"Is he married or single?"

"Oh! Single, my dear, to be sure! A single man of large fortune; four or five thousand a year. What a fine thing for our girls!"

"How so? How can it affect them?"

"My dear Mr. Bennet," replied his wife, "how can you be so tiresome! You must know that I am thinking of his marrying one of them."

"Is that his design in settling here?"

"Design! Nonsense, how can you talk so! But it is very likely that he may fall in love with one of them, and therefore you must visit him as soon as he comes."

Mr. Bennet was so odd a mixture of quick parts, sarcastic humour, reserve, and caprice, that the experience of three-and-twenty years had been insufficient to make his wife understand his character. Her mind was less difficult to develop. She was a woman of mean understanding, little information, and uncertain temper. When she was discontented, she fancied herself nervous. The business of her life was to get her daughters married; its solace was visiting and news.

CHAPTER II

Mr. Bennet Visits Mr. Bingley

Mr. Bennet was among the earliest of those who waited on Mr. Bingley. He had always intended to visit him, though to the last always assuring his wife that he should not go; and till the evening after the visit was paid she had no knowledge of it. It was then disclosed in the following manner.

Observing his second daughter employed in trimming a hat, he suddenly addressed her with: "I hope Mr. Bingley will like it, Lizzy."

"We are not in a way to know what Mr. Bingley likes," said her mother resentfully, "since we are not to visit."

"But you forget, mamma," said Elizabeth, "that we shall meet him at the assemblies, and that Mrs. Long promised to introduce him."

"I do not believe Mrs. Long will do any such thing. She has two nieces of her own. She is a selfish, hypocritical woman, and I have no opinion of her."

"No more have I," said Mr. Bennet; "and I am glad to find that you do not depend on her serving you."

CHAPTER III

The Meryton Assembly

Not all that Mrs. Bennet, however, with the assistance of her five daughters, could ask on the subject, was sufficient to draw from her husband any satisfactory description of Mr. Bingley. They attacked him in various ways -- with barefaced questions, ingenious suppositions, and distant surmises; but he eluded the skill of them all, and they were at last obliged to accept the second-hand intelligence of their neighbour, Lady Lucas.

Mr. Bingley was good-looking and gentlemanlike; he had a pleasant countenance, and easy, unaffected manners. His sisters were fine women, with an air of decided fashion. His brother-in-law, Mr. Hurst, merely looked the gentleman; but his friend Mr. Darcy soon drew the attention of the room by his fine, tall person, handsome features, noble mien, and the report which was in general circulation within five minutes after his entrance, of his having ten thousand a year.

In this section of Pride and Prejudice (1813), Jane Austen develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in romance and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

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CHAPTER IV

Reflections of Jane and Elizabeth

*Pride and Prejudice * Jane Austen (1813)*

Reflections of Jane and Elizabeth continues Jane Austen's inquiry in Pride and Prejudice. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

First published in January 1813, Pride and Prejudice remains Jane Austen's most celebrated work of social observation and romantic wit. Set among the landed gentry of rural England, the novel follows the spirited Elizabeth Bennet, the second of five daughters of a country gentleman whose estate is entailed away from the female line.

When the wealthy and amiable Charles Bingley leases nearby Netherfield Park -- accompanied by his reserved, seemingly haughty friend Fitzwilliam Darcy -- a sequence of assemblies, visits, and misunderstandings tests both Elizabeth's quick judgment and Darcy's entrenched pride.

This complete digital edition reproduces the authoritative 1813 text with clean chapter typography, restored scene breaks, and full Web Reader access.

Throughout Chapter IV (Reflections of Jane and Elizabeth), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned Pride and Prejudice its stature in the Classic Romance & Social Comedy canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, Jane Austen traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

CHAPTER V

Lucas Lodge Conversations

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Morning Calls and Drawing-Room Wit

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The Walk to Netherfield

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CHAPTER VIII

Evening in the Netherfield Drawing-Room

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